SAUDI MARKET TRENDS PLATFORM

Strategy & Hypotheses

Market positioning, advantages, and the open questions we plan to answer

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> Companion to `ARCHITECTURE.md`. The architecture answers *how we build it*; this doc answers *why anyone should care* and *what we still need to prove*. Source: founder concept brief (Hybrid SaaS — Founder-Market Fit + Product-Market Fit, KSA-first).

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1. Where we play

A **Venture Decision-Support platform** that bridges two questions most tools answer separately:

- **“What business should I start?”** → Founder-Market Fit path (B2C — individuals)
- **“Should I launch this product?”** → Product-Market Fit path (B2B — existing businesses)

We’re not selling a report. We’re selling an **Opportunity Radar** — continuous market intelligence that compounds in value the longer a customer subscribes.

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2. Market advantages (ranked by defensibility)

Defensibility = how hard it is for a global competitor to copy us in 6 months. Highest first.

A. KSA-native by construction, not by translation

Almost every competitor (IdeaBuddy, Validator AI, Upmetrics, Venturekit) is a US/EU product with an Arabic UI bolted on. Our architecture treats KSA as the **first-class** case:

- **Hijri calendar is a primary axis** in the seasonal engine — competitors will surface “buy dates in March” while we’ll surface “buy dates 6 weeks before Ramadan, with confidence intervals from 3 prior cycles.”
- **Saudi-dialect NLP** (كيف / يبه / وش / code-switching) captures the actual signal in TikTok comments and X replies that MSA-only NER drops.
- **Snapchat is in the source mix** — Snap dominates in KSA youth segments and is invisible to almost every Western trend tool.
- **KSA event calendar** (Riyadh Season, National Day, Founding Day, Hajj) is hardcoded into the seasonal engine.

Why it’s a moat: to copy this, a global competitor has to rebuild their NLP pipeline, calendar logic, and source mix. They won’t bother for a market our size — but for a Saudi founder, the difference is the difference between useful and not.

B. Founder × Market matching is genuinely novel

The competitive landscape splits cleanly:

Category	What they do	What they miss
Validator AI / IdeaBuddy / Venturekit	Score the *idea*	Ignore who's running it
Lucidya / Crowd Analyzer / Brand24	Score the *market*	Don't connect to a person/decision
Consulting offices	Score idea + market	Slow, expensive, no monthly cadence
ChatGPT / Gemini	Generic answers	No scoring, no memory, no signal

Founder-Market Fit Score × Product-Market Fit Score in one platform isn't a feature — it's a different shape. It means we can recommend "this opportunity is large but not for *you*, here's a closer-fit alternative" — something no analysis-only tool can do.

C. Continuous beats one-shot

A traditional feasibility study is dead the day it's printed. Markets move. Our **Monthly Market Watch** turns a one-time decision into an ongoing relationship — which is also why MRR works as a business model.

For the customer: alerts when a competitor launches, when a trend shifts, when a new opportunity emerges in their tracked categories. For us: retention compounds, and every month of usage produces feedback that improves the recommender.

D. Decision-support output, not analysis output

Output is **a ranked recommendation with a reason**, not a 40-page deck. Every screen ends in a verb: launch / delay / pivot / test small. This is the "selling a decision, not a report" framing — and it's defensible because it forces us to be opinionated, which generic LLM tools structurally can't be (they hedge by default).

E. Synthetic-data-first means we ship in a hackathon

Most competitors couldn't demo without real data licenses. We've engineered the system so the trend engines work on synthetic-but-realistically-shaped data (see `data/synthetic/`). At the hackathon this is a demo advantage; post-hackathon it's a wedge — we can onboard pilot customers with **demo data of their own category** before real data partnerships close.

Honest weaknesses (call out before judges do)

- **Snapchat data access is unsolved** — the architecture lists it as a gap. We'll likely ship Phase 1 without it and negotiate later.
- **Trust in AI for business decisions in KSA is unproven** — this is hypothesis H5 below.
- **Total addressable market is bounded** — KSA founders + SMBs is a real but finite market. Expansion path: GCC → wider MENA, but the moat (KSA-native) shrinks as we expand.
- **B2C monthly subscription is hard** — most consumer SaaS dies on retention. This is hypothesis H1 below.

3. Positioning statement

> Unlike traditional market-research tools that analyze only the market, and unlike business-plan generators that ignore the founder, **our platform analyzes both the founder and the Saudi market** to recommend a specific business opportunity or product-launch decision — and keeps recommending as the market moves.

Three audience-specific reframes:

- **To a founder:** *"Know which business fits you, before you invest a riyal."*
- **To a small business:** *"Test the launch before you bet on it."*
- **To an incubator:** *"Evaluate 50 founder applications with one consistent methodology."*

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4. Open research questions

Each of the following is a **question**, not a claim we are trying to confirm. Each question has multiple plausible answers; we list each plausible answer alongside what it would imply for the product and the architecture. We do not pre-commit to which answer is "good for us." If the data points away from our current design, the right move is to update the design — not to dismiss the data.

> **On framing.** Section 2 lists positioning *claims* (advantages we believe we have). The questions below are how we test whether those claims hold. Some of them, if answered honestly, may invalidate parts of Section 2 — that is intended.

Demand questions — *what is the market actually willing to pay for?*

#	Question	Method	Plausible findings
Q1	At what price points and with what billing model (one-time / monthly / freemium / pay-per-report) do Saudi early-stage founders express willingness to pay for ongoing market intelligence — *if any*?	Van Westendorp price-sensitivity survey + landing-page A/B with 3 SKU framings, paid waitlist with refundable deposit	(a) Monthly preferred at 49–99 SAR; (b) one-time preferred at 200–500 SAR; (c) free is the only thing they'll use; (d) bimodal (small power-user segment willing to pay much more)
Q2	What do Saudi SMBs *currently use* to validate a new product before launch, and what would they need to see in order to switch?	10–15 in-depth jobs-to-be-done interviews with SMB owners launching a product in the next 90 days	(a) Already pay consultants; (b) use ChatGPT / intuition; (c) don't validate at all; (d) use existing software (which?)
Q3	What evaluation methodology do Saudi accelerators / universities / incubators currently use for cohort selection and ongoing tracking, and where do they see gaps?	5+ stakeholder interviews (Misk, KAUST, Monsha'at, others)	(a) Manual / committee-based with no software; (b) systematic but missing ongoing tracking; (c) already have a tool that works; (d) selection is solved, but post-cohort founder support is not
Q4	What is the price elasticity in the 49–999 SAR/mo range, separately for B2C and B2B segments?	Gabor-Granger study, n ≥ 50 per segment	Elastic / inelastic by tier; could land anywhere

Value questions — *does the product actually change a decision?*

#	Question	Method	Plausible findings
Q5	How do users describe the relationship between an AI-generated business recommendation and their actual decision — 30 days after exposure?	30-day diary study with 20 founders; semi-structured exit interview	(a) Acted on the recommendation; (b) considered but didn't act; (c) decided the opposite; (d) never opened the report; (e) trusted some parts, not others
Q6	How does the predictive accuracy of (Founder-Market Fit + Product-Market Fit) score compare against (a) random, (b) market-only score, (c) founder-only assessment, (d) expert judgement, when scored retrospectively against business outcomes?	Backtest on 30+ KSA founders with known 12–24-month outcomes (still operating, revenue band, pivot count)	Combined could be: best, equal to market-only, worse than expert judgement, or all of them indistinguishable from random
Q7	When shown side-by-side outputs from our system, ChatGPT, and a global AI business tool for the same brief, which does the user pick to act on, and why?	Blinded comparison study, n = 20 founders	(a) Ours wins clearly; (b) ChatGPT wins on speed/ familiarity; (c) global tool wins on trust/brand; (d) preference depends on the question type

Feasibility questions — *what does the system actually need in order to produce credible output?*

#	Question	Method	Plausible findings
Q8	Across 5 categories (F&B, fashion, gaming, beauty, services), what is the precision/recall of our trend engines using only OSINT + Google Trends + X Basic — and how does that compare to adding TikTok/IG/Snap data?	90-day backtest; ground-truth labels from category experts	High in all categories; high in some but not others; uniformly poor without paid sources; better in long-term than short-term
Q9	What questionnaire length produces a Founder Profile score that is stable on test-retest (correlation > 0.7) and how does length affect completion?	Cohort study with multiple lengths; 7-day re-test	(a) Short (5–10 min) is stable; (b) only long is stable; (c) stability is poor regardless; (d) only behavioral signal (not self-report) is stable
Q10	What share of users who receive a trend alert take any observable action (click, save, share, change tracked categories, message support) within 7 days, and what do non-actors say when asked?	Cohort analytics + lightweight exit survey	High action; low action but high session retention (passive consumption); low action and low retention (alerts annoying); category-dependent

Channel questions — *how do we actually reach customers?*

#	Question	Method	Plausible findings
Q11	For Saudi founders 22–35, which channel produces the highest-quality leads (defined as: completed onboarding **and** 30-day retention) — TikTok, X, LinkedIn, university partnerships, or paid search?	Multi-channel pilot with controlled spend, source-attributed	Any of them could win; channel × persona interaction is likely
Q12	What is the share of Saudi founders who prefer Arabic-first / English-first / bilingual interfaces, and how does that correlate with stage, sector, and education?	50-founder survey + landing-page A/B	Arabic-first dominates; English-first dominates; mixed by sector; preference shifts with stage
Q13	Are incubator / university partnerships a sustainable distribution channel — i.e., do partner-sourced users retain at the same rate as self-serve users?	90-day cohort retention by acquisition source	Same; partner users retain better; partner users retain worse (free-rider effect)

Competitive questions — *what is the moat actually made of?*

#	Question	Method	Plausible findings
Q14	Over a 6-month observation window, do global market-intelligence competitors release KSA-specific features (Hijri calendar, Saudi-dialect NLP, KSA event awareness, Snapchat data)?	Competitor changelog & feature monitoring	None do; one or two add Arabic UI but not Hijri/dialect; multiple do (moat closes); a regional competitor we missed already exists
Q15	What does a Saudi founder say when asked to describe — in their own words, unaided — what makes a market-intelligence tool feel “Saudi-built” vs “translated”?	Open-ended interviews, n = 15	Hijri calendar matters; doesn’t matter; matters but they assume any tool has it; only Snapchat data matters; only Arabic dialect matters

5. Triage for the hackathon week

Triage by **information value per hour**, not by which answer would be most flattering. The questions below are the highest-value to investigate during hackathon week because (a) they are cheap to run, (b) any plausible finding meaningfully changes the next decision, and (c) they unblock more downstream work than other questions.

Priority	Question	Why now	What we'd do with each plausible answer
1	**Q1** (pricing & willingness to pay)	If pricing assumptions are wrong, every other product decision is wrong	Monthly viable → keep current model; one-time preferred → re-architect to report-first; free-only → reposition or pivot to B2B-first
2	**Q8** (data sufficiency)	Determines whether we can ship without paid data partnerships	Sufficient → ship Phase 1 as designed; sufficient only in some categories → category-tier the launch; insufficient → invest now in TikTok Research access or partnerships
3	**Q3** (incubator gap)	Cheap interviews; one strong "yes, we'd pay for that" reframes the GTM	Gap exists → pursue B2B2C now; no gap → focus on direct B2C
4	**Q15** (what "Saudi-built" means in their words)	Tells us whether our claimed moat (Hijri, dialect, Snap, KSA calendar) is the *actual* moat or whether something else matters more	Confirms our list → invest more; reveals different priorities → re-rank advantages in Section 2

Q5–Q7 (trust, predictive accuracy, comparative usefulness) are critical but cannot be answered in a week — schedule them for the 2-4 week window after the hackathon.